PROJECT RIHAI: BREAKING THE BARRIERS BETWEEN BAIL AND FREEDOM

(Comprehensive Narrative Document, 2020–2025)

India's prison system stands at the intersection of justice, inequality and urgent humanitarian need. Between 2020 and 2025, the country witnessed a persistent crisis marked by overcrowded jails, an exceptionally high proportion of undertrial prisoners, and a deeply troubling reality—thousands of individuals remained in jail even after being granted bail, simply because they were too poor to furnish bail bonds or sureties. Project Rihai emerges against this backdrop: a mission to ensure that freedom is not determined by a prisoner's wallet but by the principles of justice and dignity.

Between 2020 and 2022, official NCRB Prison Statistics India (PSI) data shows a steady rise in the total prison population: 4.88 lakh inmates in 2020, 5.54 lakh in 2021, and 5.73 lakh in 2022. Throughout this period, undertrial prisoners consistently represented 75–77% of all inmates, highlighting the delays, inequalities, and systemic gaps in India's criminal justice process. By January 2025, national NALSA–UTRC data recorded approximately 5.06 lakh prisoners, with undertrials again forming more than 74% of the population. Despite minor declines or temporary releases through special drives, the fundamental structure remained unchanged: India's prisons, sanctioned for far fewer people, continued operating at alarmingly high capacities—often between 150% and 250% in several states.

Even more distressing is the subgroup of prisoners who technically *should not be in prison at all*: those who have been granted bail but remain locked up due to inability to pay bonds, fines, or sureties. In 2023 alone, 24,879 undertrial prisoners could not be released despite bail orders—Uttar Pradesh accounting for 6,158 of them. In 2024, a nationwide special BNSS release campaign identified 951 prisoners eligible for release, but only 334 could actually exit prison. The remaining 617 remained incarcerated due to the same cycle of poverty. By early 2025, UTRCs reviewed over 13,430 cases across India, and still only 334 managed to secure release. More than 12,000 individuals, legally eligible for freedom, stayed imprisoned simply because they were too poor.

Behind these numbers lie real, painful stories. One such example is Vinay—a young man imprisoned in Tihar Jail on a robbery charge. Though he admitted his mistake and the court granted him bail, he could not secure release. His mother, living in a cramped slum, had no property, no savings, and no assets to serve as surety. With no income and no support system, she could not furnish even the minimal bail amount demanded. Thus, Vinay's right to bail—a right meant to restore dignity and trust—became meaningless. His life remained frozen behind bars, not because of law, but because of poverty. His story mirrors thousands of others across India: individuals caught not in the web of crime, but in the web of economic disadvantage.

At the same time, India's justice system attempted partial remedies through Lok Adalats, which serve as alternative dispute resolution platforms enabling quick, low-cost settlements. Between 2020 and 2025, national Lok Adalats disposed of millions of cases—1.58 crore in a single drive in 2023 and over 1.12 crore in 2024. They also played a role during Covid-19 by facilitating releases under Section 436A

CrPC and minor offenses. Yet, the core challenge remained: while courts grant bail, the socio-economic system ensures that real freedom remains out of reach for the poorest.

It is within this landscape that **Project Rihai** was born—a community-driven effort to free those unjustly trapped behind bars. The project focuses on prisoners who have already completed their legal sentences or have been granted bail but remain incarcerated purely because they cannot afford bail bonds or fines. In India, a bail bond is a financial or property guarantee required by courts to ensure compliance with bail conditions. For middle-class or wealthy families, such requirements are routine. For millions of India's poorest, they are insurmountable walls. Project Rihai seeks to tear down this wall by raising funds through crowdfunding and charitable contributions. The aim is simple yet transformative: help a prisoner step out of jail, return home, reunite with family, restart livelihood, and reclaim dignity.

The urgency behind the project cannot be overstated. Prison overcrowding severely deteriorates living standards, mental health, and rehabilitation opportunities for inmates. Families, especially children, endure prolonged emotional, social, and economic suffering. Mothers run households alone, elderly parents struggle, and young children grow up without guidance. A system intended to deliver justice instead inflicts further punishment on those who are already poor and marginalized. When the poorest citizens remain incarcerated due to money they do not have, the credibility and fairness of the entire justice system are called into question.

Project Rihai operates with the belief that **bail is not just a legal privilege—it is a human right**. Justice cannot be reserved for those with resources while the poor remain condemned to indefinite imprisonment. Through financial assistance, legal aid support, community engagement, and public awareness, the initiative works to ensure that no person remains behind bars because they cannot afford freedom. Every contribution—whether ₹500 or ₹5,000—has the power to change a life. It pays a bail bond, opens prison gates, and gives a human being a second chance. It brings someone home.

In summary, the years 2020 to 2025 reveal a painful but undeniable truth: India's prisons are full not of hardened criminals, but of people who are trapped by poverty. Project Rihai stands as a beacon of hope in this unequal landscape. It is more than a fundraising initiative—it is a movement to restore justice, humanity, and dignity. By supporting the project, donors become agents of liberation, helping turn locked doors into pathways of possibility. Every life freed is a life renewed. Every freedom restored is a step toward a more just society.

Greetings from Project Second Chance!

Hope this message finds you well.
We have closely followed your efforts to help prisoners facing legal and financial barriers to release; it is evident that our goals go hand in hand.
At Project Second Chance, we work to change that. We identify individuals who need legal aid, counseling, and reintegration assistance to help them rebuild their lives.
Our new program, Project Rihaai ('Release'), is committed to supporting people held in pre-trial detention through the provision of direct funding of bail bonds and essential costs of legal representation.

We’re reaching out to explore how we can work together. By pooling resources and networks, we can speed up the bail process for inmates who are ready for release but unable to pay. Project Rihaai’s legal team carefully vets each case so our funding reaches those in need.
If you’re open to collaboration, we’d love to discuss how targeted funding and joint advocacy can help restore dignity and freedom to more individuals.
Thank you,
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https://www.projectsecondchance.in
to Donate: http://m-lp.co/prisoner-1?utm_medium=campaign_page_share&utm_source=copy.

Project Rihaai

Freedom Beyond Bail: Bring Someone Home

Many individuals stay in jail even after bail is granted only because they cannot afford the amount.
Families struggle to collect funds, leaving loved ones behind bars. We are here to help.

Contact Us For More Information:
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PROJECT SECOND CHANCE

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Subject: Collaboration Proposal: Supporting 30 Prisoners Through Project Rihaai (₹6 Lakhs | 6 Months)

Greetings from **Project Second Chance**,

Hope this message finds you well.

We have been closely following your dedicated efforts to support prisoners who continue to face **legal, financial, and systemic barriers**—including those who remain incarcerated **even after being granted bail** because they cannot afford the bail bond or surety requirements. It is clear that our missions deeply align. Like you, we believe that **freedom should not depend on wealth**, and that justice must extend equally to the most vulnerable.

At **Project Second Chance**, we work to change this reality. Our team identifies individuals in custody who urgently need **legal assistance, psychological support, and reintegration planning** so they can return to their families and rebuild their lives. Building on this mission, we have launched **Project Rihaai**, a targeted intervention designed to free people held in **pre-trial detention** or those who have **completed their sentences** but remain behind bars solely due to the **inability to pay bail bonds, sureties, or fines**.

Project Rihaai ('Release') provides:

- **Direct funding of bail bonds and surety amounts**
- **Legal representation and follow-up support**
- **Assistance with documentation and court compliance**
- **Post-release counselling and reintegration guidance**

Our legal team carefully vets every case to ensure that support reaches those who need it most—individuals who are legally eligible for release but financially trapped.

As you know, India's prison crisis is severe:

- Over **5.3 lakh prisoners** (2025), with **74% being undertrials**
- Many facilities operating at **150–250%** of their sanctioned capacity
- Thousands granted **bail but not release** because they cannot afford the bail bond
- In 2023 alone, **24,879 undertrial prisoners** remained in jail despite bail
- In 2024's national special drive, **617 prisoners** could not be released simply due to lack of surety
- As of Jan 2025, **12,000+ eligible prisoners** were still stuck behind bars

This crisis represents more than overcrowding—it is a human tragedy. Families sink deeper into poverty, prisoners suffer prolonged and unnecessary incarceration, and the justice system's credibility weakens when **freedom depends not on innocence or eligibility, but on money**.

With this context, we believe our collaboration can create meaningful, measurable impact.

Our Proposal:

Freeing 30 Prisoners | ₹6,00,000 Support | 6-Month Target**

We aim to partner with your organisation to release **30 individuals** who have been granted bail but remain incarcerated due to financial barriers. Through **Project Rihaai**, we propose:

- **₹6 lakhs** of dedicated funding
- **30 prisoners released over 6 months**
- **Average bail bond support: ₹15,000–₹20,000 per person**
- **Legal screening, documentation, and follow-up by our legal team**
- **Counselling and post-release reintegration support**

This will not only reunite families but also **reduce overcrowding**, remove **unnecessary financial suffering**, and strengthen **trust in the justice system**.

By pooling our resources, networks, and expertise, we can accelerate the release process for prisoners who deserve freedom today—not years later.

We would be grateful for the opportunity to meet and discuss how we can design a collaborative model that channels **targeted funding**, strengthens **joint advocacy**, and restores **dignity and hope** to those trapped in the system.

Thank you for the important work you do, and for considering this partnership. Together, we can ensure that **poverty never becomes a prison sentence**.

Warm regards,

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Project Rihaai

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